

Friday, 17 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Partly cloudy 28° 16°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 28° 15°	MANCHESTER Light drizzle 25° 16°	GLASGOW Overcast 25° 14°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

The uncle of a man arrested in connection with the death of Ann Widdecombe has spoken of his shock, saying his legs "went like jelly."

Police are holding a suspect on suspicion of murder. The victim's body was found at her home last week. It's a truly shocking development in a high-profile case.

CRIME · UK
- 2

A court has heard harrowing details of a man accused of killing a woman as she slept next to her baby, and stabbing another man.

Daniel Sean James, 46, is on trial for the murder of Kirandeep Kaur in her own home. The prosecution is laying out its case in what promises to be a difficult hearing.

CRIME · UK
- 3

Outgoing Prime Minister Keir Starmer has made a final visit to Ukraine, pledging "unwavering support" for the country in its war with Russia.

He met with President Zelensky, reassuring him of the UK's continued commitment. It marks one of Starmer's last acts as Prime Minister before a new leader takes over.

POLITICS · UK
- 4

The government has U-turned on plans to stop paying Coastguard volunteers, following widespread concern and criticism.

Transport minister Keir Mather confirmed the decision, saying he had listened to the views of rescue officers. It's a victory for the volunteers who play a vital role in safety.

PUBLIC SERVICES · UK
- 5

TikTok is facing an investigation from Ofcom over its child age verification processes, after concerns about children's safety on the platform.

The regulator previously criticised TikTok in May, stating it wasn't "safe enough" for younger users. This new inquiry will put further pressure on the social media giant.

TECHNOLOGY · UK

What's coming up

1 Critics are raving about Sir Christopher Nolan's latest film, 'The Odyssey', calling it a "colossal piece of cinema."

Starring Matt Damon and Zendaya, it's Nolan's first movie since the blockbuster 'Oppenheimer'. It sounds like another must-see epic for film fans.

ON AIR – Are you excited for Christopher Nolan's new film, or do you think his movies are a bit too serious?

FILM · COMING SOON

2 Fans of David Bowie are in for a treat, with ten previously unheard tracks from his early career set to be released.

These recordings are from the 1960s, when Bowie performed under the name Davie Jones. It's a fascinating glimpse into the very beginnings of a music legend.

ON AIR – What's your favourite David Bowie era? Are you excited to hear these early tracks?

MUSIC · COMING SOON

3 Latin superstar Bad Bunny made history in London, becoming the first Latin artist to headline a UK stadium show.

His performance was described as a mix of "pride and a party." It's a huge moment for Latin music and a fantastic night for his fans.

ON AIR – Were you there for Bad Bunny's historic show? What's the best concert you've been to recently?

MUSIC · THIS WEEK

4 Michael Sheen is starring in a new comedy film about UFOs, inspired by his own claim of seeing one over his hometown.

The film is the debut from director Simon Ryninks and draws on his west Wales roots. It sounds like a fun, quirky watch, especially with Sheen in the lead.

ON AIR – Do you believe in UFOs? And would you like to see Michael Sheen in a comedy about them?

FILM · COMING SOON

5 Bollywood star Nora Fatehi hopes her official FIFA World Cup song will bring "unity" as she prepares to perform at the opening ceremony.

The Canadian-born artist will be taking to the stage in Toronto. It's a huge platform for her and a chance to share her message globally.

ON AIR – What are your hopes for the World Cup opening ceremony? Do you think music can bring people together?

MUSIC · COMING SOON

On the schedule

1 Jofra Archer delivered an "excellent" performance, taking quick wickets to put England in control against India in the second one-day international.

Archer took back-to-back wickets, narrowly missing a hat-trick as India slipped to 193-7. It's a strong showing from England as they look to dominate the match in Cardiff.

ON AIR – How crucial is Jofra Archer to England's white-ball team? And what's your favourite cricket hat-trick moment?

CRICKET · UK

2 Scotland's rugby team will remember the late Scott Hastings at Murrayfield this Saturday, with a special jersey to be worn by Smith.

Hastings, a Scottish rugby legend, passed away in May at 61. It will be an emotional occasion as Scotland host Fiji in their final summer series game.

ON AIR – What are your fondest memories of Scott Hastings? And how important is it to honour sporting legends?

RUGBY · UK

3 Red Bull will be changing their rear wing for the Belgian Grand Prix after Max Verstappen's high-speed crashes in the previous two races.

The team is reverting to a conventional wing in a bid to improve stability. It's a critical adjustment as they look to avoid further incidents and maintain their championship lead.

ON AIR – Do you think Red Bull's wing change will solve their issues? And what's been the most dramatic moment in F1 this season?

F1 · THIS WEEK

4 Wales captain Dewi Lake has recovered from injury and will play against South Africa in the Nations Championship match in Durban on Saturday.

His return is a boost for Wales as they name their squad to face the Springboks. It's a crucial fixture for the team, and Lake's leadership will be vital.

ON AIR – How important is Dewi Lake's return for Wales? And what are your predictions for this weekend's rugby internationals?

RUGBY · UK

5 Midfielder Joao Gomes is reportedly close to a £38 million move to Aston Villa from Wolves, following their relegation from the Premier League.

Gomes is set to be a key signing for Villa as they look to strengthen their squad. It's a significant transfer that could reshape both teams' fortunes.

ON AIR – What do you make of this potential transfer? And which Premier League team do you think needs to make the biggest signing this summer?

FOOTBALL · UK

Quick hits

- 1 Scientists are finding that simply looking at 'green spaces' can significantly improve mood and reduce stress.**
Research suggests that even a brief view of trees or plants from a window can have a positive impact on our mental well-being, proving nature's calming effect.
- 2 The surprising popularity of 'communal gardening plots' is blossoming in urban areas across the UK.**
More city dwellers are discovering the joys of growing their own produce and sharing the experience, fostering community spirit and fresh harvests.
- 3 A new trend sees people embracing the charm of 'vintage travel posters' to decorate their homes.**
These classic designs evoke a sense of nostalgia and adventure, inspiring daydreams of past holidays and future getaways right from the living room.
- 4 Experts highlight the unique comfort found in 'listening to the gentle hum of household appliances'.**
For many, the consistent background noise of a fridge or a washing machine offers a subtle, reassuring presence, creating a feeling of domestic calm.
- 5 The art of 'creating personalised mixtapes' (or playlists) for friends is making a sentimental comeback.**
It's a thoughtful way to share music and show someone you care, curating tunes that bring back memories or introduce new favourites.
- 6 More people are finding joy in the simple act of 'feeding garden birds' and observing their antics.**
Setting up a bird feeder provides endless entertainment and a connection to nature, right in your own backyard.
- 7 The trend of 'swapping homemade jams and preserves' with neighbours is gaining delicious momentum.**
It's a lovely way to share culinary creations, reduce waste, and build friendly connections within your local community.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to decide what to wear in the morning?

ANSWER: ASKING AN IMAGINARY AUDIENCE FOR THEIR OPINION IN THE MIRROR.

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'ritual' they absolutely have to perform before sending an important email, just to make sure it's perfect?

ANSWER: READING IT ALOUD IN A SILLY VOICE TO CATCH ANY AWKWARD PHRASING.

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes a particular 'smell' can instantly transport you back to a specific memory or a moment from your past?**

What's that one smell – maybe freshly cut grass, an old book, or a specific baking aroma – that instantly unlocks a flood of memories for you, and what memory is it?

- **We all have those 'little everyday moments' that just make us smile, even if they seem insignificant to others.**

What's a small, simple moment in your day that never fails to bring a little bit of joy to your face, and why does it make you happy?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Octopuses have three hearts: two pump blood through the gills, and one circulates it to the rest of the body.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Penguins can fly, but only when they're underwater, using their strong wings to propel themselves through the ocean currents.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£9.5 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£9.5 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The Great Barrier Reef is the largest living structure on Earth and can be seen from outer space.
- A group of owls is called a parliament.
- Strawberries are the only fruit that wear their seeds on the outside.
- The Eiffel Tower can be 15 cm taller during the summer due to thermal expansion of the iron.
- It is impossible for most people to lick their own elbow.
- There are more possible iterations of a game of chess than there are atoms in the known universe.
- The first recorded use of the word 'OK' was in 1839.
- Bubble wrap was originally intended to be used as three-dimensional wallpaper.

On this day

Day 198 of the year, 167 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Alexius of Rome (Western Church); Christian feast day: Andrew Zorard; Christian feast day: Cynehelm; Christian feast day: Cynllo. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1980 — Brett Goldstein, British actor, comedian and writer
- 1935 — Peter Schickele, American composer and educator (died 2024)
- 1961 — Jeremy Hardy, English comedian and actor (died 2019)
- 1975 — Konnie Huq, English television presenter
- 1976 — Brian K. Vaughan, American comic book and television writer
- 1940 — Tim Brooke-Taylor, English actor and screenwriter (died 2020)
- 1939 — Spencer Davis, Welsh singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2020)
- 1965 — Alex Winter, British-American actor

THE DAY TODAY

- 2000 — During approach to Lok Nayak Jayaprakash Airport, Alliance Air Flight 7412 suddenly crashes into a residential neighborhood in Patna, India, killing 60 people.
- 1998 — The 7.0 Mw Papua New Guinea earthquake triggers a tsunami that destroys ten villages in Papua New Guinea, killing up to 2,700 people, and leaving several thousand injured.
- 1953 — The largest number of United States midshipman casualties in a single event results from an aircraft crash in Florida, killing 44.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1717 — King George I of Great Britain sails down the River Thames with a barge of 50 musicians, where George Frideric Handel's Water Music is premiered.
- 1997 — After takeoff from Husein Sastranegara International Airport, Sempati Air Flight 304 crashes into a residential neighborhood in Bandung, killing 28 people.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1976 — East Timor is annexed and becomes the 27th province of Indonesia.
- 1944 — Port Chicago disaster: Near the San Francisco Bay, two ships laden with ammunition for the war explode in Port Chicago, California, killing 320.

- 1968 — Abdul Rahman Arif is overthrown and the Ba'ath Party is installed as the governing power in Iraq with Ahmed Hassan al-Bakr as the new Iraqi President.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 199 of the year, 166 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Arnulf of Metz; Christian feast day: Bruno of Segni; Christian feast day: Camillus de Lellis (optional memorial, United States only); Christian feast day: Eadburh (or Edburga) of Bicester. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1985 — James Norton, English actor
- 1926 — Nita Bieber, American actress (died 2019)
- 1985 — Chace Crawford, American actor
- 1941 — Lonnie Mack, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2016)
- 1950 — Glenn Hughes, American disco singer and actor (died 2001)
- 1938 — John Connelly, English footballer (died 2012)
- 1954 — Ricky Skaggs, American singer-songwriter, mandolin player, and producer
- 1923 — Michael Medwin, English actor (died 2020)

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1982 — Two hundred sixty-eight Guatemalan campesinos ("peasants" or "country people") are slain in the Plan de Sánchez massacre.
- 1942 — The Germans test fly the Messerschmitt Me 262 using its jet engines for the first time.
- 1970 — An Antonov An-22 of the Soviet Air Forces crashes into the Atlantic Ocean, killing all 23 aboard.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1996 — Storms provoke severe flooding on the Saguenay River, beginning one of Quebec's costliest natural disasters ever.
- 1992 — A picture of Les Horribles Cernettes was taken, which became the first ever photo posted to the World Wide Web.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026	
FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)